

Chapter 104-2

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Liang Shi witnessed what a grand production looked like.

During the experience, someone even explained that this was a set that had been used for a TV program's recording, and after changing the story, it was reopened for everyone to play.

The stages after that got harder one after another. Starting from the elevator, it became a turning point—they were often trapped in a single space for an hour.

Throughout this time, Liang Shi and Xu Qingzhu stayed together. The experienced player who had gone to do the solo task rejoined them at the sixth stage.

By this point, everyone was exhausted.

They had no idea how much time had passed outside. All their phones had been placed in lockers. They couldn't find clues, and the clues they did find couldn't be connected. Everyone was completely confused.

Moreover, they constantly had to face scares while searching for clues.

Especially when Liang Shi picked up a crystal ball while searching for clues in the sixth stage—she then fell into a trap. A wooden panel suddenly opened, and she dropped straight down, landing on a cushioned mat. Her scene immediately switched, while the others were trapped in another space.

The space she was in was completely dark—so dark she couldn't see her hand in front of her face. After entering, she called out for Xu Qingzhu several times, only to find that the other person couldn't hear her voice at all. However, she could hear the others' voices.

She heard Xu Qingzhu calling for her and also heard everyone discussing what kind of space she had entered.

She sat on the cushioned mat, mustered up her courage to reach out and feel around, but touched nothing.

After a while, she heard Xu Qingzhu call out: "Liang Shi, if you're scared, just lean against the wall, close your eyes, and wait for me to come to you."

"That's not possible," the experienced player said. "She needs to do a solo task now. There must be clues on her side waiting for her to find, and then combined with the clues on our side, we can pass this stage together."

Liang Shi answered in a low voice: "I'll try to look around."

The people outside couldn't hear her response either.

Liang Shi didn't particularly like dark environments, but it wasn't to the point of being afraid.

It was because darkness tends to amplify all of one's senses—at such times, whether it was sounds or touches, everything became more sensitive.

It was probably because she had performed so poorly while watching the horror movie that day that Xu Qingzhu thought she was ridiculously timid.

Liang Shi felt it was necessary to correct this mistaken image of herself in Xu Qingzhu's mind.

She slowly braced herself against the wall and stood up. Knowing nothing about escape rooms, she tried to find a light switch on the wall, but there was nothing.

The wall was very smooth—there was nothing at all.

Once her eyes adjusted to the darkness, she could make out a few things here. For instance, in the right corner, there was a reflective mirror.

She didn't know where the light it was reflecting came from.

When she picked up the mirror, she discovered it was one that could light up—the kind of touch-activated makeup mirror commonly seen.

But in this situation, in this environment, a glowing mirror that could show a person's face was even scarier.

At the very least, when Liang Shi turned on that mirror and saw her own face, she thought it was an NPC and was badly startled.

However, by flipping the mirror over, it could be used as a light source. She still prioritized finding the lights first.

She searched along the wall she was leaning against but couldn't find any switch. Then she heard an argument breaking out above.

It was because Xu Qingzhu wanted Liang Shi to stay put, believing there were no usable clues on Liang Shi's side. But the remaining people all thought there must be clues where Liang Shi was, and they needed to coordinate from both sides to pass this stage.

The immersive escape room experience they had purchased was a complete package. The price was very expensive—nearly three thousand per person—with a ten-hour time limit. Only if they couldn't get out within ten hours would the safety passage be opened for them.

At other times, there was no way out provided—unless someone fainted from fright or was scared out of their wits, crying and saying they didn't want to play anymore, waving at the camera and saying the safety word. Then someone would come to escort them out. Once out, it would be considered giving up, and there would be no refund.

So most people wanted to finish playing.

People who came to play this kind of thing generally weren't short on money, but spending several hours in an escape room made people very uncomfortable.

The dark environment, the crowd of people, even the air wasn't fresh.

It made it impossible for people to talk properly.

When they first entered, everyone seemed very easy to get along with, but by the later stages, everyone's patience was nearly exhausted. They just wanted to quickly solve the puzzles, clear the stages, and leave this place.

Xu Qingzhu's suggestion was like asking everyone to stay trapped in the escape room, so naturally, no one agreed.

But Xu Qingzhu said firmly: "If there are clues on her side, we should be able to hear her voice. But right now we can't hear anything, so I'm inclined to have her stay put."

The others all disagreed, chattering away in discussion.

But Xu Qingzhu ignored them and continued searching for clues. Her movements were much faster than before.

Seeing her remain silent, the other players all looked toward the experienced escape room player. In an instant, he became the backbone of this game.

They had been particularly dependent on Xu Qingzhu for the previous stages because her logical reasoning ability was very strong—she could even solve astrophysics problems. So at the beginning, everyone had joked that they'd encountered a top student and didn't need to worry about being unable to solve puzzles. Analyzing logic and organizing clues were Xu Qingzhu's strong suits.

But now Xu Qingzhu had started doing everything alone, and the others all disagreed. The experienced player finally said: "Let's look for a tool that can connect with the other side. There must be one."

She still leaned toward coordinating with Liang Shi from both sides. Then she knocked on the floor panel where Liang Shi had fallen through. "Player Number 4, check if there's any tool on your side that can communicate with this side."

"How are you sure she can hear us?" someone asked.

The experienced player said: "There was a hint when she fell through just now."

The instant Liang Shi had fallen, a voice had sounded here: "Ding-a-ling, you took my crystal ball—caught you! Now your friends can't hear you speak~"

It only said her friends couldn't hear her speak, but it didn't say she couldn't hear her friends' voices.

If it were normal, it would definitely say—You can't communicate anymore!

Xu Qingzhu had also made her judgment based on this.

However, she didn't pay attention to them and continued searching for clues alone.

Meanwhile, Liang Shi in the other space had been searching with that mirror for a long time. She still hadn't found that light, but she encountered an NPC jump scare right in her face.

And it happened one after another.

The first time was a red-clothed NPC, like someone getting married¹, wearing glamorous makeup, with black hair so long it nearly dragged on the ground, hanging upside down from the ceiling.

While Liang Shi was waving the mirror around the walls, the NPC was directly illuminated by the mirror, her face only five centimeters from Liang Shi's.

An extremely intimate in-your-face jump scare.

That mirror showing Liang Shi's own face had been enough to startle her badly, let alone encountering the red-clothed NPC. She was so scared on the spot that her voice cracked when she screamed. Then her hands grabbed wildly and caught a wig.

But the wig was sticky, and she threw it on the ground in fright.

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Very scary.

Extremely scary.

Footnotes:

¹ Red-clothed NPC like someone getting married: In traditional Chinese culture, brides wear red wedding dresses. However, in Chinese horror folklore, ghosts of women who died with grievances (especially brides who died on their wedding day or women seeking vengeance) are often depicted wearing red. This makes the "red-clothed woman" (红衣女鬼) a common and particularly terrifying figure in Chinese horror media.